

Minutes of Meeting — ERP Product Research & Product Definition

1. Meeting Objective

The discussion focused on taking the ERP product to the **next level through structured market research and product definition**.

The proposed approach is to first understand:

- What functionality/features are available in competing ERP products.
- Where each feature is used.
- Which products provide the feature.
- Whether the feature is a **must-have**, **good-to-have**, or **differentiating feature**.
- How widely the feature is available across the market.
- Which industries/companies use those capabilities.

The expected output from this research is a **structured feature/product matrix** rather than simply a collection of information.

2. Market Research Approach

The market research was discussed as having **two phases**.

Phase 1 — Research & Data Collection

- Research existing ERP products.
- Identify available functionalities/features.
- Understand the use cases for each feature.
- Identify how many products provide each feature.
- Determine whether a feature is a common/must-have capability.
- Collect supporting data points.
- Prioritize the findings.

A **matrix** should ultimately be created to represent the research results.

The discussion emphasized that the team should not simply say "*this feature looks good*" but should use data to understand how common and relevant the feature is in the market.

3. Feature Prioritization

Features should eventually be classified/prioritized based on the research.

Category	Meaning
Must Have	Expected/common functionality that the product should provide
Good to Have	Useful functionality but not necessarily essential
Differentiator	Capability that can provide additional product value
Not Relevant	Feature that doesn't provide sufficient value for the target product

The exact classification/matrix is to be developed based on the research rather than assumptions.

4. Requirement → Design → Development Flow

A proposed product development lifecycle was discussed.

Market Research ↓
Feature / Product Definition ↓
Business Requirement Document (BRD) ↓
Functional Requirement Document (FRD) ↓
High-Level Design / Technical Design ↓
UI/UX Design ↓
Database / Interface Design ↓
Mock-up / Prototype ↓
Functional Validation ↓
Sign-off ↓
Development ↓
Testing ↓
Product

The discussion highlighted that **Business Analysts and Product/Project Managers** can contribute to converting the research/discovery output into a proper Business Requirement Document. The BRD can then be used by architects and designers to develop the functional and technical design.

5. Requirements Traceability

One important point discussed was maintaining a relationship between requirements and test cases.

Example:

Functional Requirement #120

↓

Test Case A
Test Case B
Test Case A.1
Test Case A.2
Test Case A.3

Therefore, if **Functional Requirement #120 changes**, the team immediately knows which test cases and potentially which other areas are affected.

This provides **traceability and impact analysis**. The requirement change should therefore be communicated with the relevant stakeholders before proceeding.

6. Prototype / Mock-up Validation

Before moving completely into development, the discussion proposed creating:

- Mock-ups
- Prototypes
- Basic functional demonstrations
- UI/UX representations
- Database concepts where required

The purpose is to make the proposed functionality **visible and understandable** before committing fully to development.

The prototype can then be reviewed and used as part of the decision/sign-off process.

7. Product Architecture Principles

A major theme of the discussion was that the new/next-level product should focus on:

Modularity — Modules should be independently structured as much as possible.

Configurability — The product should allow customer-specific requirements through configuration wherever practical rather than requiring extensive custom development.

Scalability — The product should be able to support increasing numbers of users and transactions.

Reliability / Stability — The product should be stable and reduce production issues and support requirements.

Maintainability — The design should make future changes easier.

Reduced Inter-module Dependency — Dependencies between modules should be clearly defined and minimized where possible.

These were discussed as areas where the team can create significant value even when the basic ERP workflow itself is similar to other ERP products.

8. ERP Market Research Scope

The research should not be limited to simply asking: *"What features does another ERP have?"*

- Who is using the functionality?
- Which industries use it?
- What type of companies use it?
- At what scale is it used?
- How relevant is the functionality?
- Is it available out-of-the-box?
- How common is the functionality across ERP products?
- Is it a must-have or differentiating capability?

The objective is to produce **data-driven product decisions** rather than assumptions.

9. Use of AI

AI was discussed as an **assistant to the research and product-definition process**, rather than something that should replace the team's understanding.

The team should first understand the complete product/research lifecycle and then use AI effectively within that process.

The discussion specifically cautioned against becoming biased by immediately asking AI to determine the solution before understanding the problem and context.

10. Individual Team Exercise

Each team member was asked to work **individually** initially.

The reason is to encourage different perspectives rather than everyone following the same approach.

Different people may think from different perspectives, such as:

- Product Manager
- Project Manager
- Business Analyst
- Architect
- QA
- Domain/Subject Matter Expert

The different outputs can later be brought together into a common project context.

11. Project Context

Once individual research is completed, the different outputs should eventually be brought together into a **common project context**.

The project context can contain:

- Research outputs
- Requirements
- Documents
- Rules
- Gates
- Contracts
- Design information
- Other relevant project knowledge

This allows different team members to work on different tasks while maintaining a common understanding of the overall product.

12. Immediate Expected Output

ERP Market Research Feature Matrix

Feature	ERP/Product A	ERP/Product B	ERP/Product C	Industry Usage	Frequency	Priority
Feature 1	✓	✓	✓	High	80%	Must Have
Feature 2	✓	✗	✓	Medium	50%	Good to Have
Feature 3	✗	✓	✗	Low	20%	Differentiator

The actual data needs to come from the team's research.

The meeting explicitly emphasized that the **output of the research should be a product/feature definition based on data points**, rather than just descriptive research.

13. Action Items

#	Action Item	Owner	Status
1	Perform ERP market research	Each team member	To Do
2	Identify features/functionality available in the market	Each team member	To Do
3	Identify use cases and industries for each feature	Each team member	To Do
4	Identify how widely each feature is available	Each team member	To Do
5	Prepare feature comparison matrix	Each team member	To Do
6	Prioritize features based on research/data	Team	Pending research
7	Consolidate individual research outputs	Team	Later phase
8	Develop product definition from research	Team	Later phase
9	Convert approved product definition into BRD/requirements	BA/PM	Later phase
10	Establish requirement → design → test traceability	BA/Architecture/QA	Later phase

Key Takeaway

“Don't start by deciding how to build the ERP. First understand what the market has, collect data, identify what is important, prioritize it, and then define the product.”

The longer-term objective is to build an ERP that is **more modular, configurable, scalable, stable, reliable and maintainable**, rather than simply recreating existing ERP workflows.

Next session

The team members are expected to come back with their **individual research/output**, with a short presentation/discussion of what they found and how they approached the problem.